

THE COMPLETE GUIDE TO

Major World Sports

Rules, Gameplay & How Each Sport Is Played

Football · Cricket · Basketball · Tennis · Volleyball · Badminton · Table Tennis · Baseball · Rugby · Field
Hockey · Golf · Boxing · Athletics · Swimming · Kabaddi · American Football · Ice Hockey · Handball ·
Wrestling · Formula 1

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1. Football (Soccer)

The world's most popular team sport, played in nearly every country.

Players	11 per side (plus substitutes)
Duration	90 minutes (two 45-minute halves) + stoppage time
Equipment	Football (size 5), goals, shin guards
Governing Body	FIFA

Overview

Football is played between two teams of eleven players on a rectangular grass or turf pitch with a goal at each end. It is the most widely played and watched sport on Earth, contested at every level from street games to the FIFA World Cup.

Objective

To score more goals than the opposing team by getting the ball into the opponent's goal, using any part of the body except the hands and arms (except for the goalkeeper within their penalty area).

How It's Played

- Two teams of 11 (including a goalkeeper) try to move the ball down the field using their feet, chest, or head.
- Players pass, dribble, and shoot the ball, but cannot intentionally touch it with their hands or arms.
- Only the goalkeeper may use their hands, and only within their own penalty area.
- The match is divided into two 45-minute halves with a short half-time break.
- If the score is tied at the end of regulation in knockout competitions, extra time and penalty shootouts may follow.

Scoring

- A goal is scored when the entire ball crosses the goal line between the posts and under the crossbar.
- Each goal counts as one point; the team with more goals at full time wins.
- If scores are level, the match may end in a draw (league play) or go to extra time/penalties (knockouts).

Key Rules

- Offside: an attacking player cannot receive the ball if they are nearer the goal line than both the ball and the second-last defender when the ball is played to them.

- Fouls such as tripping, pushing, or handling the ball result in a free kick for the opposing team.
- A penalty kick is awarded for a foul committed inside the defender's own penalty area.
- Yellow cards are cautions; a second yellow or a straight red card sends a player off for the rest of the match.
- Throw-ins restart play when the ball crosses the sideline; corner kicks and goal kicks restart play when it crosses the goal line.

2. Cricket

A bat-and-ball game beloved across the Indian subcontinent, UK, Australia, and beyond.

Players	11 per side
Formats	Test (5 days), ODI (50 overs), T20 (20 overs)
Equipment	Bat, ball, stumps, pads, helmet
Governing Body	ICC

Overview

Cricket is played between two teams of eleven on a large oval field with a rectangular 22-yard pitch at its centre. One team bats while the other bowls and fields, and teams switch roles once an innings ends.

Objective

To score more runs than the opposing team by hitting the ball and running between the wickets, while the fielding side tries to restrict runs and dismiss batters.

How It's Played

- A bowler delivers the ball toward a batter defending a set of three stumps (the wicket).
- The batter tries to hit the ball and score runs by running to the opposite end, or by hitting boundaries.
- The fielding team tries to get batters out (dismissed) and limit the runs scored.
- Play is organized into 'overs' — sets of six legal deliveries bowled from one end.
- An innings ends when a set number of overs is completed, all batters (except one) are out, or the batting side declares.

Scoring

- Runs are scored by batters running between the wickets, or automatically when the ball reaches the boundary (4 runs on the ground, 6 in the air).
- Extra runs (wides, no-balls, byes) can be added to the batting team's total.
- The team scoring more total runs across the match/innings wins.

Key Rules

- A batter can be dismissed in several ways: bowled, caught, leg before wicket (LBW), run out, or stumped, among others.
- Once ten of the eleven batters are out, the innings ends (the team is 'all out').

- In limited-overs cricket, each bowler can bowl only a fixed maximum number of overs.
- The captain who wins the pre-match coin toss chooses whether to bat or field first.

3. Basketball

A fast-paced indoor sport built around shooting a ball through an elevated hoop.

Players	5 per side on court
Duration	4 quarters (NBA: 12 min; FIBA: 10 min each)
Equipment	Basketball, hoop at 10 ft / 3.05 m
Governing Body	FIBA

Overview

Basketball is played by two teams of five on an indoor court with a raised hoop at each end. Invented in 1891, it is now one of the most popular sports worldwide, headlined by leagues like the NBA.

Objective

To score more points than the opponent by shooting the ball through the opposing team's hoop (basket).

How It's Played

- Players advance the ball by dribbling (bouncing) it or passing it to teammates; carrying it without dribbling is a violation called 'travelling'.
- Teams alternate between offense (trying to score) and defense (trying to prevent scoring) after each possession change.
- A shot clock forces the offensive team to attempt a shot within a set time limit (24 seconds in the NBA).
- The game is split into four quarters, with overtime periods played if the score is tied at the end of regulation.

Scoring

- A basket made from inside the three-point line is worth 2 points.
- A basket made from beyond the three-point arc is worth 3 points.
- A free throw, awarded after certain fouls, is worth 1 point.
- The team with the most points when time expires wins.

Key Rules

- Common fouls include blocking, charging, and holding an opponent; accumulating fouls can foul a player out of the game.

- Violations such as travelling, double-dribbling, and goaltending result in a turnover to the other team.
- Teams must move the ball past half-court within a limited number of seconds (8 in the NBA) or lose possession.
- Defensive three-second and shot-clock rules keep the pace of play fast and prevent stalling.

4. Tennis

A racquet sport played one-on-one or in doubles across a net.

Players	1v1 (singles) or 2v2 (doubles)
Surfaces	Grass, clay, hard court
Equipment	Racquet, tennis ball, net
Governing Body	ITF

Overview

Tennis is played on a rectangular court divided by a net, with players hitting a ball back and forth using racquets. It is showcased at four Grand Slam tournaments each year: the Australian Open, French Open, Wimbledon, and US Open.

Objective

To win points by hitting the ball into the opponent's court in a way they cannot legally return, ultimately winning enough games and sets to win the match.

How It's Played

- Players stand on opposite sides of the net and alternate hitting the ball into the opponent's half of the court.
- Each point starts with a serve, hit diagonally into the opponent's service box.
- A rally continues until a player fails to return the ball before it bounces twice, or hits it out of bounds or into the net.
- Matches are divided into games, and games into sets; players typically need to win 2 or 3 sets to win the match.

Scoring

- Points within a game are counted as 15, 30, 40, and game point; a tied score at 40-40 is called 'deuce'.
- A player must win a game by at least two points once deuce is reached.
- A set is won by the first player to reach 6 games with a two-game lead (tiebreaks resolve 6-6 ties).
- A match is won by the first player to win the required number of sets (best of 3 or best of 5).

Key Rules

- A serve that touches the net but still lands in the correct box is a 'let' and is replayed.
- Two consecutive faulted serves result in a 'double fault', giving the point to the receiver.

- In doubles, partners alternate serving turns and must stay within the wider doubles court boundaries.
- Players change ends of the court after every odd-numbered game.

5. Volleyball

A team sport where players hit a ball over a high net without letting it touch the ground.

Players	6 per side on court
Format	Best of 5 sets, first to 25 points (final set to 15)
Equipment	Volleyball, net (2.43 m men's / 2.24 m women's)
Governing Body	FIVB

Overview

Volleyball is played by two teams of six on a court divided by a tall net. Teams try to ground the ball on the opponent's side while preventing it from touching their own.

Objective

To send the ball over the net and land it in the opponent's court, or force the opposing team into an error, while preventing the ball from touching your own court.

How It's Played

- Each team can touch the ball up to three times (plus a block touch) before it must cross the net.
- A typical sequence is: dig (receive the serve), set (position the ball), and spike (attack it over the net).
- Play starts with a serve from behind the back line, hit over the net into the opponent's court.
- Players rotate positions clockwise each time their team wins back the serve.

Scoring

- Volleyball uses rally scoring: a point is awarded on every serve, regardless of which team served.
- A set is won by the first team to reach 25 points with at least a 2-point lead (the deciding set is played to 15).
- A match is won by the first team to win 3 sets (best-of-5 format).

Key Rules

- A team commits a fault if the ball touches the ground on its side, goes out of bounds, or is touched more than three times.
- Players cannot touch the net or reach over it to interfere with the opponent's play (except when blocking).
- Back-row players may not attack the ball from in front of the attack line while it is fully above net height.

- A 'let' does not exist in volleyball serving — a serve that touches the net and still lands in remains in play.

6. Badminton

A fast racquet sport played with a shuttlecock over a high net.

Players	1v1 (singles) or 2v2 (doubles)
Format	Best of 3 games to 21 points
Equipment	Racquet, shuttlecock, net (1.55 m)
Governing Body	BWF

Overview

Badminton is played on a court divided by a net, using lightweight racquets to hit a shuttlecock (or 'birdie') back and forth. It is one of the fastest racquet sports, with smashes exceeding 400 km/h.

Objective

To land the shuttlecock in the opponent's half of the court in a way they cannot return, without letting it touch your own side.

How It's Played

- A rally begins with an underarm serve hit diagonally into the receiver's service box.
- Players strike the shuttlecock back and forth over the net until it lands, goes out, or a fault occurs.
- The shuttlecock must not touch the ground on a player's side, or a point is awarded to the opponent.
- Matches are played in a best-of-three-games format.

Scoring

- Badminton uses rally scoring — a point is scored on every serve, whoever wins the rally.
- A game is won by the first player/pair to reach 21 points with at least a 2-point lead (capped at 30).
- A match is won by the first side to win 2 out of 3 games.

Key Rules

- The shuttlecock must be hit before it touches the ground; touching the net with the racquet or body is a fault.
- In singles, the server's court position (left or right) depends on whether their score is even or odd.
- Doubles partners cannot both stand anywhere on court — serving order and rotation follow set positional rules.
- Hitting the shuttlecock outside the boundary lines results in a fault and the point going to the opponent.

7. Table Tennis

Also called ping-pong — a quick, precision racquet sport played on a table.

Players	1v1 (singles) or 2v2 (doubles)
Format	Best of 7 games to 11 points
Equipment	Paddle (racquet), lightweight ball, table with net
Governing Body	ITTF

Overview

Table tennis is played on a hard table divided by a low net, with players using small paddles to hit a lightweight ball. It demands sharp reflexes and spin control.

Objective

To hit the ball so it bounces on the opponent's side of the table in a way they cannot legally return.

How It's Played

- A serve must bounce once on the server's side and then once on the receiver's side before being returned.
- After the serve, players may return the ball directly (on the fly is not allowed — it must bounce on their side first) before hitting it back.
- Players alternate hitting the ball until one side fails to make a legal return.
- Serving alternates every two points (every point in the final game after one side reaches 5).

Scoring

- A point is scored on every rally, regardless of who served (rally scoring).
- A game is won by the first player to reach 11 points with at least a 2-point lead.
- A match is typically won by the first player to win 4 out of 7 games.

Key Rules

- The ball must be tossed at least 16 cm on serve and struck behind the end of the table.
- Touching the table with your free hand or moving the table during play is a fault.
- The ball must clear the net on every shot; hitting into or under the net loses the point.
- Players switch ends after each game, and midway through the final deciding game.

8. Baseball

America's pastime — a bat-and-ball game built around innings, pitches, and home runs.

Players	9 per side on field
Duration	9 innings (no time limit)
Equipment	Bat, ball, glove, bases
Governing Body	WBSC

Overview

Baseball is played between two teams of nine, alternating between batting and fielding across nine innings. It is especially popular in the United States, Japan, and parts of Latin America.

Objective

To score more runs than the opposing team by batting the ball and advancing runners around four bases in order.

How It's Played

- A pitcher throws the ball toward a batter, who tries to hit it into fair territory with a bat.
- After a fair hit, the batter runs toward first base and may continue to additional bases if possible.
- The fielding team tries to get batters and runners out, for example by catching a fly ball or tagging a runner.
- Each team bats once per inning until three outs are recorded, then the teams switch roles; a full game is 9 innings.

Scoring

- A run is scored when a player safely advances around all four bases and touches home plate.
- A home run — hitting the ball out of the field of play in fair territory — allows the batter (and any runners on base) to score automatically.
- The team with more total runs after 9 innings wins; extra innings are played if tied.

Key Rules

- A batter is out after three strikes (swinging and missing, or not swinging at a pitch in the strike zone).
- Four pitches outside the strike zone (balls) award the batter a 'walk' to first base.
- A ball caught in the air before it touches the ground results in an automatic out (a 'fly out').
- Runners can be tagged out if not touching a base when touched with the ball by a fielder.

9. Rugby (Union)

A physical, full-contact team sport centred on carrying and passing an oval ball.

Players	15 per side
Duration	80 minutes (two 40-minute halves)
Equipment	Oval ball, no mandatory padding
Governing Body	World Rugby

Overview

Rugby union is a contact sport played by two teams of fifteen, popular in the UK, Ireland, France, and across the Southern Hemisphere (New Zealand, South Africa, Australia).

Objective

To score more points than the opponent, mainly by carrying, passing, or kicking the ball to ground it in the opponent's goal area (a 'try') or kicking it through the goal posts.

How It's Played

- Players advance the ball by running with it or passing it laterally or backward — forward passes are not allowed.
- The ball can also be kicked forward and chased, since kicking is a major tactical element.
- When a player is tackled, they must release the ball, often leading to a contested 'ruck'.
- Set pieces such as scrums and lineouts restart play after certain stoppages or infringements.

Scoring

- A try, scored by grounding the ball in the opponent's in-goal area, is worth 5 points.
- A successful conversion kick after a try adds 2 points.
- A penalty kick through the posts is worth 3 points, and a drop goal during open play is worth 3 points.
- The team with the most points after 80 minutes wins.

Key Rules

- Forward passes (thrown toward the opponent's goal line) are illegal and result in a scrum for the other team.
- Tackles must be made below the shoulders; high tackles are penalized for player safety.
- Offside laws restrict where players can stand relative to the ball during rucks, mauls, and open play.

- Players can be temporarily sin-binned (yellow card) or sent off (red card) for serious infringements.

10. Field Hockey

A stick-and-ball team sport played on grass or turf, especially popular in India, Pakistan, and Europe.

Players	11 per side
Duration	4 quarters of 15 minutes
Equipment	Hockey stick, hard ball, shin guards
Governing Body	FIH

Overview

Field hockey is played by two teams of eleven using curved sticks to hit a small hard ball, aiming to score in the opponent's goal. It has been an Olympic sport since 1908.

Objective

To score more goals than the opposing team by hitting, pushing, or flicking the ball into the opponent's goal using the flat side of the stick.

How It's Played

- Players use hockey sticks to dribble, pass, and shoot the ball across the pitch.
- Only the flat (left) side of the stick may be used to play the ball; using the rounded side is a foul.
- Players (other than the goalkeeper) cannot use their hands, feet, or body to intentionally control the ball.
- The game is divided into four 15-minute quarters with short breaks between them.

Scoring

- A goal is scored when the ball fully crosses the goal line inside the goal, typically struck from within the 'shooting circle'.
- Each goal is worth 1 point; the team with more goals when time expires wins.
- Tied knockout matches may be decided by a penalty shootout.

Key Rules

- A goal only counts if the shot is taken from within the 23-metre shooting circle in front of the goal.
- Obstruction — blocking an opponent's access to the ball with the body — is a common foul.
- Dangerous play, such as raising the ball into an opponent, is penalized.
- Penalty corners are awarded for fouls by defenders inside their shooting circle, giving the attacking team a set-piece opportunity.

11. Golf

An individual precision sport played across an outdoor course of 18 holes.

Players	Individual (or teams in some formats)
Course	Typically 18 holes
Equipment	Clubs, golf ball, tees
Governing Body	R&A; / USGA

Overview

Golf is played on a large outdoor course, where players use a set of clubs to hit a ball into a series of holes in as few strokes as possible.

Objective

To complete each hole, and the full round, using the fewest number of strokes possible.

How It's Played

- Players start each hole from a tee and hit the ball toward a distant hole marked by a flag.
- Golfers select from various clubs (drivers, irons, putters) depending on distance and terrain.
- Once on the smooth putting green, players use a putter to roll the ball into the hole.
- A standard round covers 18 holes, each with a target score called 'par' (usually 3, 4, or 5 strokes).

Scoring

- The number of strokes taken to complete a hole is recorded; fewer strokes is better.
- Scores are often described relative to par — for example, 'birdie' (1 under par) or 'bogey' (1 over par).
- In stroke play, the winner is the player with the lowest total strokes across the round(s).
- In match play, holes are won individually, and the player who wins the most holes wins the match.

Key Rules

- Players must play the ball as it lies and cannot improve its position, except under specific relief rules.
- Hitting the ball out of bounds or into a water hazard typically incurs a one-stroke penalty.
- Golf is largely self-officiated, with players expected to record their own scores honestly.
- Etiquette rules such as not talking during another player's swing and repairing divots are part of the sport's tradition.

12. Boxing

A combat sport where two competitors fight using only their fists, wearing padded gloves.

Competitors	2 (individual)
Duration	Bouts of 3-12 rounds, each 2-3 minutes
Equipment	Gloves, mouthguard, boxing ring
Governing Body	AIBA / various pro sanctioning bodies

Overview

Boxing pits two fighters of similar weight against each other in a roped ring. Each aims to land clean punches while avoiding the opponent's, under the supervision of a referee.

Objective

To win by landing more effective punches than the opponent, scoring a knockout, or being awarded victory on the judges' scorecards.

How It's Played

- Two boxers face off in a ring, throwing punches using only closed fists above the waist.
- Fighters use footwork, blocking, and head movement to land punches while avoiding their opponent's.
- A bout is divided into rounds, with a short rest period between each.
- A referee inside the ring can stop the fight for safety reasons at any time.

Scoring

- Judges score each round based on clean punches landed, ring control, and defense.
- If the fight goes the full distance, the boxer with more rounds won on the scorecards wins by decision.
- A knockout (opponent unable to continue) or technical knockout (referee stops the fight) ends the bout immediately.
- A bout can also end in a draw if judges' scores are even.

Key Rules

- Punches below the belt, to the back of the head, or with an open glove are fouls.
- A fighter knocked down must rise before a count of ten (a 'knockout') or the fight is stopped in their favor for the opponent.
- Holding, headbutting, and hitting an opponent who is down are all prohibited.

- Boxers compete within specific weight classes to ensure fairer matchups.

13. Athletics (Track & Field)

A collection of running, jumping, and throwing events, headlined by the Olympic Games.

Format	Individual and relay events
Venue	400 m oval track + field area
Equipment	Varies by event (spikes, javelin, discus, etc.)
Governing Body	World Athletics

Overview

Athletics encompasses a wide range of events, from sprints and long-distance races to jumps (long jump, high jump) and throws (shot put, javelin), usually contested on a track-and-field complex.

Objective

To run faster, jump farther/higher, or throw an implement further than all other competitors, depending on the specific event.

How It's Played

- Track events (races) are timed from start to finish, with athletes running in individual lanes for shorter sprints.
- Field events like the long jump and high jump measure the distance or height a competitor achieves in a set number of attempts.
- Throwing events such as shot put, discus, and javelin measure the distance an implement is thrown.
- Relay races involve teams of four athletes passing a baton around the track.

Scoring

- In races, the athlete with the fastest recorded time wins.
- In jumping and throwing events, the athlete with the single best measured distance or height across their attempts wins.
- Multi-event competitions like the decathlon and heptathlon award points for performance in each event, and the highest point total wins overall.

Key Rules

- False starts in sprint races (leaving the blocks before the gun) can result in disqualification.
- In jumping events, fouls occur if an athlete steps over the takeoff line before jumping.
- Relay teams must pass the baton within a designated exchange zone or be disqualified.

- Athletes are subject to strict anti-doping testing under World Athletics rules.

14. Swimming

A water-based sport contested over set distances using different recognized strokes.

Format	Individual and relay races
Venue	50 m or 25 m pool
Strokes	Freestyle, backstroke, breaststroke, butterfly
Governing Body	World Aquatics

Overview

Competitive swimming involves racing over fixed distances in a pool using one or a combination of recognized strokes. It is one of the most-watched events at the Summer Olympics.

Objective

To complete the race distance in the fastest time using the required stroke technique for that event.

How It's Played

- Swimmers start from starting blocks (or in the water for backstroke) and race down a lane to the far wall.
- In longer races, swimmers perform a 'flip turn' or touch turn at each wall before continuing.
- Individual medley races require swimmers to complete each of the four strokes in a set order over the race.
- Relay races involve four swimmers, each completing a leg of the total distance.

Scoring

- Swimming is purely time-based: the swimmer who completes the distance in the least time wins.
- Electronic touchpads at the pool wall record finishing times to the hundredth of a second.
- In relays, the team with the fastest combined time across all four legs wins.

Key Rules

- Each stroke has specific technical requirements — for example, breaststroke requires symmetrical arm and leg movements.
- Swimmers must touch the wall correctly at turns and the finish, according to the rules of their stroke.
- A false start (leaving the blocks before the starting signal) can lead to disqualification.
- Swimming outside your own lane or interfering with another swimmer results in disqualification.

15. Kabaddi

A high-intensity contact sport originating in South Asia, combining raiding and wrestling.

Players	7 per side on court
Duration	2 halves of 20 minutes (senior level)
Equipment	None — played barehanded
Governing Body	International Kabaddi Federation

Overview

Kabaddi is a raiding-and-tackling team sport that originated in the Indian subcontinent and is now popular through leagues such as the Pro Kabaddi League. Two teams occupy opposite halves of a court.

Objective

To score points by raiding into the opponent's half, touching opponents, and returning safely to your own half — or as a defender, by stopping the raider from returning.

How It's Played

- One player (the 'raider') crosses into the opposing team's half of the court and tries to touch as many defenders as possible.
- The raider must continuously chant 'kabaddi, kabaddi' in a single breath while raiding, without pausing.
- Defenders try to tackle and stop the raider from returning to their own half before taking another breath.
- Teams alternate raids, sending one raider at a time into the opposing half.

Scoring

- The raiding team earns a point for each opponent touched who fails to tackle the raider.
- The defending team earns a point if they successfully tackle and stop the raider from returning home.
- An 'all out' — dismissing every defender on the opposing team — earns the raiding team 2 bonus points.
- The team with more total points at the end of the match wins.

Key Rules

- A raider who fails to hold their breath (stops chanting 'kabaddi') before returning is declared out.

- A raider must cross the bonus line or touch a defender to score, and cross back over the mid-line to survive the raid.
- Defenders form a chain-hold to tackle the raider but cannot cross the mid-line themselves during a raid.
- Both teams alternate sending players off and on the court as they are put out or brought back into play.

16. American Football

A high-strategy, high-contact sport built around advancing an oval ball down the field in downs.

Players	11 per side on field (45+ man rosters)
Duration	4 quarters of 15 minutes
Equipment	Helmet, pads, oval ball
Governing Body	NFL / national federations

Overview

American football is played by two teams of eleven, most popular in the United States, where the NFL is the dominant professional league. Teams alternate possession and use a mix of running and passing plays to advance the ball.

Objective

To score more points than the opponent by advancing the ball into the opponent's end zone or kicking it through the goal posts.

How It's Played

- The offense has four attempts ('downs') to advance the ball at least 10 yards; succeeding resets the down count.
- Plays are run from a 'line of scrimmage', starting with a snap from the center to the quarterback.
- The offense can run with the ball or throw a forward pass to a teammate down the field.
- If the offense fails to gain 10 yards in four downs, possession transfers to the other team, often after a punt.

Scoring

- A touchdown, scored by getting the ball into the opponent's end zone, is worth 6 points.
- After a touchdown, teams can add 1 point (extra-point kick) or 2 points (two-point conversion).
- A field goal, kicking the ball through the goal posts during regular play, is worth 3 points.
- A safety, tackling an opponent with the ball in their own end zone, awards 2 points to the defense.

Key Rules

- Only one forward pass is allowed per play, and it must be thrown from behind the line of scrimmage.
- Defensive players cannot contact receivers beyond 5 yards before the ball is thrown (illegal contact/pass interference rules apply).

- A play ends when the ball carrier is tackled, steps out of bounds, or a pass is incomplete.
- Penalties such as holding or offside result in yardage being added or subtracted from the offense's position.

17. Ice Hockey

A fast, physical sport played on ice, popular in Canada, the US, and across Northern Europe.

Players	6 per side on ice (including goalie)
Duration	3 periods of 20 minutes
Equipment	Stick, puck, skates, full protective gear
Governing Body	IIHF

Overview

Ice hockey is played by two teams of six skaters on an ice rink, using curved sticks to shoot a rubber puck into the opponent's goal. It combines speed, skill, and physical contact.

Objective

To score more goals than the opposing team by shooting the puck into their goal net.

How It's Played

- Players skate on ice, using sticks to pass, carry, and shoot a hard rubber puck.
- Teams try to advance the puck into the offensive zone and generate scoring chances against the opposing goaltender.
- Body checking (physical contact to separate an opponent from the puck) is legal within the rules.
- The game is divided into three 20-minute periods, with teams switching ends between periods.

Scoring

- A goal is scored when the puck fully crosses the goal line inside the net; each goal is worth 1 point.
- The team with more goals after three periods wins; tied games may go to overtime and a shootout.
- An 'assist' is credited to the player(s) who helped set up a goal, though it does not add to the score.

Key Rules

- Icing is called when a team shoots the puck the length of the ice without it being touched, resulting in a stoppage.
- Offside occurs if an attacking player enters the offensive zone before the puck does.
- Penalties (like tripping or high-sticking) send a player to the penalty box, leaving their team short-handed (a 'power play' for the opponent).
- Fighting is penalized but, unlike many sports, typically results in a timed penalty rather than automatic ejection in most leagues.

18. Handball

An indoor team sport combining elements of basketball and football, played with the hands.

Players	7 per side on court (6 outfield + 1 goalkeeper)
Duration	2 halves of 30 minutes
Equipment	Handball, goal (2 m x 3 m)
Governing Body	IHF

Overview

Handball is played by two teams of seven on an indoor court, with players throwing a ball with their hands to score in a goal defended by a goalkeeper. It is especially popular across Europe.

Objective

To score more goals than the opposing team by throwing the ball into the opponent's goal.

How It's Played

- Players move the ball by passing, bouncing (dribbling), or taking up to three steps while holding it.
- Attackers try to break through the defense and shoot from within or near a marked 6-metre zone in front of the goal.
- Only the goalkeeper is allowed to defend inside the 6-metre goal area.
- The game is played in two 30-minute halves with a short half-time interval.

Scoring

- A goal is scored when the ball fully crosses the goal line into the net; each goal counts as 1 point.
- The team with the most goals at the end of the match wins.
- Tied knockout matches typically go to a penalty shootout after extra time.

Key Rules

- A player may hold the ball for a maximum of 3 seconds and take a maximum of 3 steps before passing, dribbling, or shooting.
- Outfield players cannot step inside the goalkeeper's 6-metre area while playing the ball.
- Physical contact such as pushing or holding an opponent's arm is penalized as a foul.
- Repeated fouls can lead to a 2-minute suspension, leaving the offending team short-handed.

19. Wrestling

One of the oldest combat sports, focused on taking down and controlling an opponent.

Competitors	2 (individual)
Styles	Freestyle and Greco-Roman (Olympic)
Duration	2 periods of 3 minutes
Governing Body	United World Wrestling

Overview

Wrestling is a grappling combat sport where two competitors try to gain and maintain a physical advantage over each other, typically ending with a pin or points-based decision. It has been part of the Olympics since ancient times.

Objective

To win by pinning the opponent's shoulders to the mat, or by scoring more points through takedowns and control than the opponent.

How It's Played

- Two wrestlers compete on a circular mat, trying to control and take down their opponent.
- In freestyle wrestling, competitors may use both their arms and legs to attack and defend.
- In Greco-Roman wrestling, holds below the waist and using the legs to trip or lift are not allowed.
- A match is contested over two three-minute periods, with the wrestler winning more points across periods declared the winner.

Scoring

- Points are awarded for actions like takedowns, reversals, and exposing an opponent's back to the mat.
- A 'pin' (or 'fall'), holding both of the opponent's shoulders to the mat, ends the match immediately as a win.
- If no pin occurs, the wrestler with more total points when time expires wins by decision.

Key Rules

- Wrestlers compete within specific weight classes to ensure fair matchups.
- Dangerous or illegal holds, such as strangleholds or twisting an opponent's joints beyond a safe range, are prohibited.
- A wrestler can win by technical superiority if they build a large enough points lead during the match.

- Passivity (avoiding engagement) can be penalized by the referee to encourage active wrestling.

20. Formula 1 Racing

The pinnacle of open-wheel motorsport, contested by elite drivers and constructor teams.

Competitors	20 drivers, 10 teams
Race Length	~305 km per Grand Prix
Equipment	Single-seat open-wheel race car
Governing Body	FIA

Overview

Formula 1 is a series of Grand Prix races held on closed circuits and street tracks around the world, where drivers pilot highly engineered single-seat cars for both individual and constructor (team) championships.

Objective

To complete a set number of laps faster than every other driver, and over a season, accumulate the most championship points for both drivers and constructors.

How It's Played

- Drivers first compete in qualifying sessions to determine their starting position ('grid') for the race.
- Races are run over a fixed number of laps of a circuit, typically totaling around 305 kilometres.
- Drivers must make at least one pit stop during the race to change tyres, which are engineered for different track and weather conditions.
- Strategy, car performance, and driver skill all combine to determine the finishing order.

Scoring

- Points are awarded to the top 10 finishers in each race, with 25 points for first place, descending to 1 point for tenth.
- An additional point is available for the fastest lap of the race, if achieved by a top-10 finisher.
- Points accumulate across the season to determine the Drivers' Champion and Constructors' Champion.

Key Rules

- Cars must conform to strict technical regulations on dimensions, weight, and power unit specifications.
- Overtaking rules and track limits are enforced by race stewards, who can issue time or grid penalties for infringements.

- Drivers who cause avoidable collisions or ignore flag signals (like blue flags for lapped traffic) can be penalized.
- Each team fields two cars, and constructors' points combine the results of both drivers.